



Cover story

OVERHAULING the Police

Radically change the image and status of men in khaki for them to become weapons against terror



From its introduction into the British Empire in 1895 to the time it gave way to self-loading rifles in the 1960s, the .303 Lee-Enfield rifle was an outstanding weapon. But today, this antique rifle which has to be manually loaded for each shot, and is standard issue for India's policemen symbolises the asymmetry between them and the terrorists they must face: an aging, outmoded weapon pitted against the AK-47 that can spit 30 bullets in one automatic burst.

Locomotives of India's growth story, the six metros are magnets for investment and prime targets for terrorists. Booming growth has outstripped investment in security infrastructure over the years, with the police force having been nibbled away by corruption and systemic neglect. When faced with a threat like the attacks on Mumbai, it collapses.

India's police forces are grossly understaffed. The country has one of the lowest policemen to population ratios in the world, just 142 per lakh people compared to ratios of 250 per lakh in Western countries. The

40,000-strong Mumbai Police, for instance, is short by 15 per cent on manpower and heavily overstretched. This is the case in most metros.

The forces don't have modern communication equipment, little personal protection like bullet-proof jackets and helmets and, worse, no specialised teams to deal with heavy assaults. Even the bomb disposal squads are understaffed and underequipped.

There is also an asymmetry between the Centre and states when it comes to technology and fighting terror. Part of this has to do with the legacy of the 1980s where terror was essentially confined to north India—Punjab, Jammu and Kashmir and New Delhi. The Home Ministry created the National Security Guard (NSG), a one-stop shop to deal with hijackings, bomb threats and urban assaults. With terrorism spreading into the hinterland and the new spectre of suicide commandos, metro police forces have been caught unprepared.

Metros are now abjectly dependent on distantly located forces like the NSG not only for the Special Force personnel but



also for bomb squads and post-blast forensic investigations. Funds are left unutilised. For instance, in 2006-07, states spent just over 60 per cent of liberal Central grants, returning unspent money even as the backlog of basic equipment like X-ray machines, modern weapons and communication tools, piled up.

There is little that has not been already said about the crying need to reform the police force. At least five police reform committees since 1998 headed by Julio Ribeiro, Justice Malimath, Padmanabhaiah, Soli Sorabjee and Veerappa Moily have said repeated ad nauseum. "It would be prudent for the policy makers to realise that the present-day challenge to internal security, especially those posed by covert designs of Pakistan's ISI or Maoist-Marxist extremist groups are of such a

INDIA HAS ONE OF THE LOWEST POLICEMEN TO POPULATION RATIOS IN THE WORLD, AT JUST THREE PER 2,000, LESS THAN HALF THE NUMBER COMPARED TO THE US.